

CityServe

Premium local services, made convenient for Thapar.

Project Proposal

Submitted as part of the Software Engineering project

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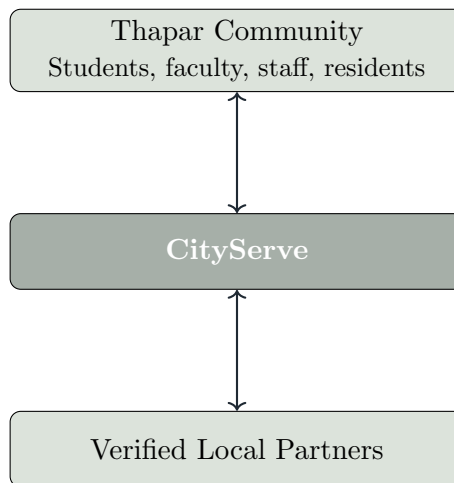
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1 Overview

CityServe is a premium local-services marketplace conceived initially for the Thapar Institute of Engineering and Technology (TIET) ecosystem and the areas immediately surrounding it. At its core, CityServe tries to answer a simple question: when a member of the Thapar community needs a local product or service, how can that need be met with less effort, more confidence, and a clearer sense of who they are dealing with?

The platform sits between two groups that already exist but are not well connected today.



CityServe is built around two core functions that work together rather than as separate products.

1. **Local directory and discovery** – helping users find and compare providers of everyday services and products.
2. **Local marketplace and transactions** – allowing users to actually book, order, pay for, and track those services, instead of stopping at a phone number or a name.

Through the directory, a user can discover providers, search for a specific service or product, compare available options, view ratings and reviews left by other users, check indicative pricing, and check availability before committing to anything. Through the marketplace, the same user can go further: book a service, place an order, choose a convenient time or delivery slot, pay online, track progress, and leave a review once the transaction is complete.

Put together, the intended flow for a typical user looks like this:



1.1 Target Audience

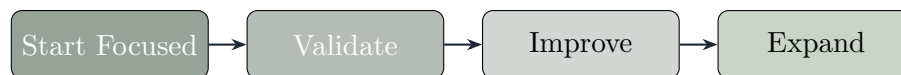
The initial target audience for CityServe consists of people who are already part of, or closely connected to, the Thapar ecosystem:

- Thapar students, both hostellers and day scholars

- Faculty and academic staff
- Non-teaching staff
- Researchers and postgraduate scholars
- Campus residents
- Nearby residents who routinely interact with the Thapar ecosystem

Thapar is a deliberate starting point rather than an arbitrary one. It represents a concentrated community living within a defined geographic area, with recurring day-to-day needs – food, laundry, repairs, personal care – and an existing base of local service providers around campus who already serve this community informally. This makes it considerably easier to validate whether the core idea works, easier to onboard a first set of partners, and easier to collect direct feedback from real users within a short distance of the team itself.

The intended approach can be summarized as:



1.2 Core Value Proposition

CityServe is not designed to compete primarily on the lowest price. Instead, it focuses on a combination of trust, quality, convenience, reliability, freshness where relevant, doorstep delivery, and time saved for the user.

The underlying idea is straightforward: the customer is not always paying more for the product or service itself. Often, they are paying for the convenience, reliability, and trust that surrounds it – the assurance that the provider is verified, that the delivery will happen as promised, and that a poor experience can be reviewed and addressed rather than simply forgotten.

2 More Nuanced Perspective

This section goes deeper into why the problem exists, why a solution built around trust and convenience can justify a premium, and how this proposal has tried to stay grounded rather than overly optimistic.

2.1 Understanding the Existing Problem

Today, most students and residents around Thapar find local services through informal, scattered channels: word of mouth, WhatsApp groups, friends who happen to know someone, random contacts saved from a flyer or a senior, or a quick and often unreliable online search.

This process is inconvenient in ways that are easy to overlook precisely because everyone is used to them:

- **Difficult discovery** – a new student has no easy way to find out which local providers even exist for a given need.

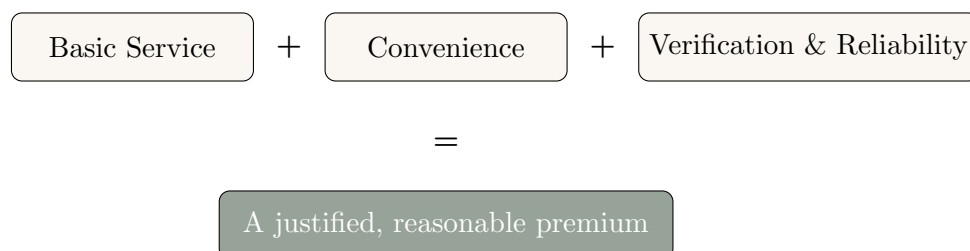
- **Uncertain quality** – there is no consistent way to know whether a provider is reliable before actually using them.
- **Unclear pricing** – prices are often negotiated informally or communicated verbally, with no easy way to compare.
- **No centralized reviews** – feedback lives in scattered conversations rather than in one place others can see.
- **Uncertain availability** – a user often does not know if a provider is even open, free, or accepting new requests.
- **Coordination effort** – arranging pickup times, delivery slots, or service visits usually happens over multiple back-and-forth messages or calls.
- **Lack of tracking** – once a request is made, the user has little visibility into its status.
- **Limited accountability** – if something goes wrong, there is rarely a structured way to raise or resolve the issue.

It is not that no platform exists in a generic sense; general listing sites and search engines exist. The real gap is that none of them are built around this specific community, and none of them combine discovery with an actual, trackable transaction.

2.2 Why Would Someone Pay a Premium?

A central question this proposal tries to address honestly is: why would a student, who is often price-sensitive, choose to pay somewhat more for something they could arrange informally for less?

The answer lies in the distinction between price and value. Price is what is paid; value is what is actually received in return, and value is not limited to the physical product or the base service. When a basic service is combined with better convenience, verification, reliability, and doorstep delivery, the combination can reasonably justify a modest premium over the completely informal alternative – without positioning every service on the platform as expensive.



2.3 Why Thapar First?

Launching within a concentrated ecosystem such as Thapar, rather than an entire city, offers practical advantages during an early and uncertain stage of the product.

- A smaller, well-defined initial market that is easier to reason about

- Easier validation of assumptions with real users
- Easier access to conduct informal user interviews
- Easier onboarding of a first set of local partners who already serve this community
- Easier quality control over a smaller number of active partners
- Faster word-of-mouth within a tightly connected community
- Faster feedback loops, since users and the team are physically close

Rather than attempting to *build for everyone*, the intention is to *build for a clearly defined community with recurring needs*, and expand only once the core assumptions have held up in practice.

2.4 Customer Perspective

From the customer's side, what is actually being valued is rarely the product alone. It is time, trust, convenience, quality, and predictability. A student balancing coursework, assignments, and a limited schedule may reasonably prefer a slightly more expensive but dependable service over a cheaper option that requires more personal effort and carries more uncertainty.

2.5 Local Partner Perspective

CityServe is designed to create value on both sides of the transaction, not just for the customer. For a local partner – a small dairy, a tailor, a laundry service, an electrician, or a home-cook – joining the platform can offer digital visibility they would not otherwise have, direct access to the Thapar customer base, more structured bookings and orders instead of ad-hoc phone calls, an online reputation built through reviews, better discoverability among a large and concentrated set of potential customers, and the possibility of recurring, repeat customers rather than one-off transactions.

2.6 Why CityServe Is More Than a Directory

It is useful to be explicit about the distinction between a directory and a marketplace.

A pure directory essentially says: *here are some local providers*. A marketplace goes further and says: *here are providers, and you can actually transact with them, right here*.

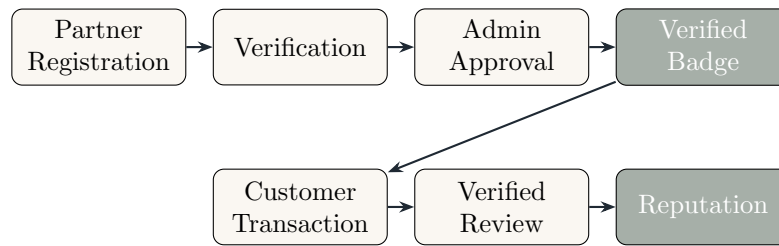
Layer	What it offers
Directory	Discover, Compare, View ratings and pricing
Marketplace	Book, Order, Pay, Track, Review

CityServe is designed to combine both layers into a single experience, so that discovering a provider and actually transacting with them do not require switching to a different tool such as a phone call or a separate payment app.

2.7 Trust as the Core Layer

Because CityServe asks customers to consider paying a premium in some cases, trust cannot be an afterthought. It is intended to run through the entire flow, from the moment

a partner joins the platform to the moment a customer leaves a review.



Trust is especially important precisely because customers are being asked, in some cases, to pay somewhat more than the fully informal alternative; that additional cost only makes sense if the platform reliably delivers on verification and reliability.

2.8 Practical Limitations

It would be misleading to present this proposal as free of risk or difficulty. Several practical challenges are acknowledged directly:

- Partner quality must be actively maintained; verification is only useful if it is enforced consistently.
- Onboarding the first set of local partners will require real, manual effort and cannot be assumed to happen automatically.
- Customer adoption and willingness to actually use the platform, rather than default back to informal channels, must be validated rather than assumed.
- Premium pricing must be tested carefully; it cannot simply be imposed without evidence that users see the value.
- Service quality ultimately depends partly on the partners themselves, which is outside the platform's direct control.
- Reliance on external services such as payment gateways or maps may introduce ongoing costs and dependencies.
- Initial data on providers, pricing, and demand will be limited until the platform has been used for some time.

These limitations are not reasons to avoid building CityServe; they are reasons to begin with a focused, minimum viable product rather than a fully-built platform, so that assumptions can be tested with real users before committing to a larger build.

2.9 MVP Philosophy

The intention is not to build every possible feature before learning whether the core idea works. Instead, the minimum viable product is designed to test a small number of specific questions:

1. Will users actually discover local services through CityServe, rather than falling back on informal channels?
2. Will they trust providers who are marked as verified?

3. Are they willing to pay a reasonable premium for convenience, reliability, and quality?
4. Will local partners actually participate and keep their listings active?
5. Will users return for recurring services, rather than using the platform once?

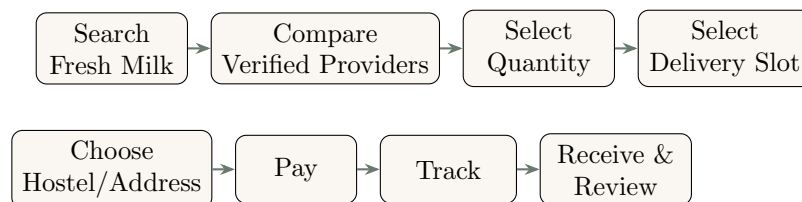
Only once these questions have been reasonably answered does it make sense to expand scope further.

3 Example Details

The following scenarios describe how a user might realistically move through CityServe for different everyday needs. They are illustrative walkthroughs of the intended experience, not records of an already-built or already-used system.

3.1 Example 1: Fresh Milk

A Thapar student needs fresh milk delivered every morning and currently has to arrange this manually, often through an informal local contact with no fixed schedule guarantee.



The premium value here comes from freshness, a verified source, and a dependable delivery slot, removing the need to renegotiate arrangements every few days.

3.2 Example 2: Tailor, Rafu, and Dyeing

A student needs a dress altered, a small rafu repair done, or a garment dyed. Today, this typically means asking friends for a contact or searching around locally without much sense of quality or pricing beforehand.

On CityServe, the student searches for “Rafu,” sees nearby providers along with their ratings, views an estimated price range, requests a pickup, tracks the status of the garment, receives it once completed, and leaves a review. This category is intended to cover tailoring, stitching, alteration, and dyeing services together, since they are often needed from the same or similar local providers.

3.3 Example 3: Laundry

A student without time to visit a laundry service selects a laundry provider on the platform, schedules a pickup, has the clothes collected, cleaned, and ironed, and then delivered back before leaving a review. The doorstep convenience of not having to carry laundry back and forth, combined with a scheduled pickup and delivery window, is a reasonable basis for a service fee on top of the base cleaning cost.

3.4 Example 4: Electrician

A student faces an urgent electrical issue in their room or accommodation. They search for an electrician, see a set of verified professionals, compare their ratings and indicative pricing, check availability, and book a visit. The professional arrives, completes the service, payment is made through the platform, and the student leaves a review afterward. The value here is speed and verification during a situation where the student may not otherwise know whom to call.

3.5 Service Ecosystem

Beyond the specific examples above, CityServe is intended to eventually cover a broader set of everyday local service categories. It is important to note that not all categories are expected to launch on day one; the platform is meant to start focused and expand based on demonstrated demand.

Category	Category
Fresh Essentials	Home Services
Food and Tiffin	Appliance and Electronics Repair
Laundry and Clothing	Personal Care
Tailor, Rafu, and Dyer	Automobile Services
Education and Tutoring	Photography and Events
Shoe and Leather Repair	Other Everyday Local Services

3.6 Minimum Viable Product Scope

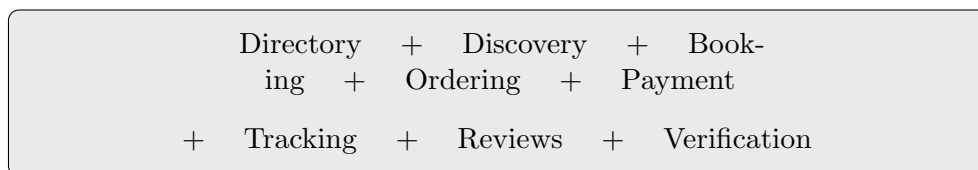
The following table summarizes the intended MVP scope across the three sides of the platform. This describes proposed functionality for the initial version, not features that are already fully implemented.

Area	Customer	Partner	Admin
Onboarding	Registration and login	Registration and verification	Partner verification
Profile	Address management, favorites	Provider profile, services/products	User and partner management
Discovery	Search, directory, provider profiles	Pricing and availability	–
Transactions	Booking, ordering, cart, payments	Order/booking management	Orders and bookings oversight
Post-transaction	Tracking, reviews, notifications	Earnings, reviews	Reports and review moderation
Insight	–	–	Analytics

4 Concluding

CityServe is a focused attempt to solve a practical, everyday local problem within the Thapar ecosystem: the difficulty of discovering, trusting, and transacting with local service providers through channels that are currently informal and scattered.

The platform is designed to combine directory-style discovery with actual booking, ordering, payment, tracking, reviews, and partner verification, rather than stopping at simply listing providers.



The initial focus is deliberately Thapar, rather than an entire city, because a smaller and well-defined community makes it realistic to test the platform's central assumptions. The objective of this early phase is to validate whether users genuinely value, and are willing to pay a reasonable premium for, convenience, trust, quality, reliability, and doorstep service.

If these assumptions hold up under real use, the model is intended to expand outward in stages:



CityServe aims to become the trusted convenience layer between local demand and local supply.

4.1 Proposed Technical Direction

At the proposal stage, the following technology direction is being considered for the eventual build. This is a proposed stack rather than a finalized or fully implemented architecture, and it may evolve as the project progresses.

Layer	Proposed Technology
Frontend	Next.js, React, TypeScript, Tailwind CSS
Backend	Node.js, Express.js, TypeScript
Database	PostgreSQL with Prisma ORM
Maps and Location	Mapbox
Payments	Razorpay
Authentication	JWT-based or secure server-side sessions
Media Storage	Cloudinary or an equivalent managed storage service

This stack is intended to support a directory and marketplace experience with reasonable performance, structured data, and dependable payment and location handling, while remaining practical for a student team to build and maintain during the course of this project.

4.2 Next Deliverable

Next Deliverable: A functional Thapar-focused CityServe prototype demonstrating the core customer, partner, and transaction journeys described in this proposal. The prototype is intended to be developed iteratively, and is not presented here as already complete.